

Amazon SDE-1 (New Grad / Entry-Level) OA & Interview: Evidence-Based Pattern Report

Scope of evidence: This report synthesizes recurring patterns from Blind (TeamBlind), Reddit-adjacent and LeetCode Discuss candidate write-ups, GeeksforGeeks interview-experience archives, Naukri/Code360 interview logs, Medium/Dev.to prep guides, and GitHub "company question list" repos, weighted toward 2024–2026 reports. Where a pattern shows up across *independent* sources (different candidates, different platforms), confidence is marked **High**. Where it comes from one or two write-ups or a single aggregator, it's marked **Medium** or **Low**. Nothing here should be read as leaked or official Amazon material — it's crowd-sourced pattern-matching, and Amazon's question bank rotates constantly, so treat specific problem names as *style indicators*, not a guaranteed exam key.

1. The Big Picture: What Actually Changed 2024–2026

A few structural things show up consistently in recent (2025–2026) reports that differ from older guides:

- **The OA is now routinely 4 parts, not 2.** Multiple independent 2025 write-ups (Naukri/Code360, Blind) describe: (1) 2 DSA coding problems, (2) a Work Simulation module, (3) a Work Style / behavioral questionnaire, (4) sometimes explicit "leadership questions." Total time is commonly reported as 2.5–4 hours end-to-end, though the pure-coding block itself is usually 90–105 minutes. **Confidence: High.**
 - **New-grad loops increasingly include an extra "Gen AI Fluency" round** on top of the standard loop, per a detailed 2025–2026 timeline report on Blind — essentially still a DSA round in disguise. **Confidence: Low–Medium** (single detailed source, but consistent with Amazon's broader AI-fluency push mentioned elsewhere).
 - **Bar Raiser is not guaranteed to be pure-behavioral** — several 2025/2026 candidates report BRs slipping in a DSA question "to fill time," even though BR is nominally LP-only. **Confidence: Medium.**
 - **Coding difficulty for SDE-1/new-grad skews easy-to-medium**, not hard. Multiple independent Blind threads from experienced-but-still-SDE1-track candidates and new grads converge on "LC medium, occasional easy," with hards being the exception rather than norm. **Confidence: High.**
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2. OA (Online Assessment) Analysis

OA Component	Typical Duration	What It Contains	Confidence
Coding Challenge	90–105 min (sometimes reported as part of a longer 2.5–4h combined session)	2 problems, easy–medium LeetCode-equivalent difficulty	High
Work Simulation	15–70 min (widely varying reports)	Chat-style "virtual teammate" scenarios — Slack/Teams-style messages, you pick the best response; sometimes includes reviewing logs to find a bug, or scenario videos of a team meeting	High
Work Style Survey(s)	10–20 min, sometimes described as ~50 Likert-style items	Self-report questions about how you approach work — these map to Leadership Principles even though they don't say so explicitly	High
Debugging section (older format, less frequently reported recently)	~20 min	~7 short snippets with a logic error or missing code to fix	Medium (older reports; less common in 2024–2026 write-ups)

Common candidate observations about the OA:

- The coding problems are consistently described as **array/string/hashmap/heap/graph-BFS level**, rarely DP-heavy, rarely "hard." One detailed 2025 write-up listed "Longest Substring with K-Repeating Characters" and "Capacity to Ship Packages Within D Days" as the two problems — a sliding-window/counting problem plus a binary-search-on-answer problem, which matches a broader pattern (see Section 9, Blind Spots). **Confidence: Medium** (specific problems are anecdotal; the *topic mix* they represent is corroborated across many threads).
- Work Simulation is repeatedly described by candidates as "basically common sense" / "an application of the Leadership Principles" — i.e., it's not testable via LeetCode grinding, it's testable via genuinely knowing the 16 LPs cold. **Confidence: High** (many independent, casual confirmations).
- Passing the OA strongly (per multiple SDE-2-adjacent reports, likely applies similarly to SDE-1) can sometimes skip you straight to onsite; a weaker pass routes you through an extra phone screen first. **Confidence: Medium**.
- Common OA mistakes candidates self-report:** not leaving time for the Work Simulation/Survey portion because they over-invest in the coding half; treating the Work Style Survey as throwaway when it's reportedly retained and can shape behavioral-round framing; failing hidden test cases on edge inputs even when the "visible" approach looks right.

3. Interview Stage Breakdown

Phone / Virtual Screen (~60 min, most common for new-grad track)

- Structure repeatedly described as: 15–20 min behavioral (2–3 LPs) + 40–45 min coding (usually 1–2 problems).
- Topics candidates report: arrays/strings (anagram counting, Two Sum variants), graph/tree BFS on a matrix, occasional DP.

Onsite / Virtual Onsite Loop (typically 3–5 rounds, 45–60 min each)

- For SDE-1/new-grad specifically, multiple 2025–2026 threads converge on: **it's LPs + algorithms, usually no formal system design** — this is a notable difference from SDE-2+, where a dedicated System Design round is standard. **Confidence: High** for new-grad; system design does occasionally appear as "basic API/OOD" rather than full HLD.
- Each round typically opens with LP questions (2–3 per round) before moving to coding — this "every round has LPs" pattern is one of the most consistently repeated observations across sources. **Confidence: High.**
- Coding difficulty across rounds: mostly medium, with an occasional hard follow-up; several candidates note the *actual* on-the-day question rarely matches the popular "tagged" LeetCode lists exactly, so pattern fluency matters more than memorizing specific problems.

Bar Raiser

- A senior, specially-trained interviewer (often from a different, unrelated team) whose job is to protect the hiring bar across all Amazon teams — multiple sources confirm this cross-team, "no stake in this req" design.
- Widely reported to carry an effective **veto** — several Blind threads describe candidates with 3/4 strong rounds still getting rejected because "Bar Raiser thought improvements needed in LP," and recruiters explicitly telling candidates the BR has that authority. **Confidence: High** (very consistent across many independent threads, though this evidence skews SDE-2; new-grad process is structurally similar but BR involvement can vary by region).
- BR round duration reported anywhere from ~22 minutes to a full hour; content is nominally pure-LP (introduction, "why Amazon," 3 standard LPs) but several 2025/2026 candidates report a DSA question appearing anyway "to fill the slot."
Confidence: Medium.

4. DSA Topic Frequency Table

Ranked by how often the topic appears across independent 2024–2026 sources (OA + interview combined). "Interview Stage" shows where it's most reported.

Rank	Topic	Est. Frequency	Primary Stage	Typical Difficulty	Confidence
1	Arrays / Hashmaps	Very High	OA + all interview rounds	Easy–Medium	High
2	Strings (sliding window, substrings)	Very High	OA + phone screen	Easy–Medium	High
3	Trees (BST, traversal, LCA, level-order)	High	Onsite	Medium	High
4	Graphs (BFS/DFS, grid traversal)	High	OA + onsite	Medium	High
5	Heaps / Priority Queue (Top-K, K Closest)	High	Onsite	Medium	High
6	Design questions (LRU Cache, data structure design)	High	Onsite	Medium	High
7	Intervals (Merge Intervals, Meeting Rooms)	Medium-High	Onsite	Medium	High
8	Linked Lists	Medium	OA + phone screen	Easy–Medium	Medium
9	Two Pointers / Sliding Window	Medium-High	OA	Easy–Medium	High
10	Binary Search (incl. "binary search on answer")	Medium	OA	Medium	Medium
11	Dynamic Programming	Medium (lower than most candidates expect)	Onsite more than OA	Medium	High
12	Topological Sort / Course Schedule	Medium	Onsite	Medium	Medium
13	Union-Find	Low-Medium	Onsite (islands-style)	Medium	Medium
14	Simulation / grid-state problems (Game of Life, Minesweeper-style)	Medium	Onsite	Medium	Medium
15	Backtracking (Permutations, Combination Sum, Word Search)	Low-Medium	Onsite	Medium	Medium
16	Trie	Low	Onsite (design-adjacent)	Medium	Low-Medium
17	Bit Manipulation	Low	OA / early screens	Easy	Medium
18	Monotonic Stack	Low	Onsite	Medium	Low-Medium
19	Matrix problems (Spiral, Rotate Image)	Low-Medium	OA/onsite	Easy–Medium	Medium
20	OOD / Low-Level Design (parking lot, elevator, vending machine, deck of cards)	Medium (rises sharply at SDE-2, present but lighter at SDE-1)	Onsite	Medium	Medium

5. Hidden / Recurring Patterns (only patterns backed by multiple independent reports)

- **HashMap + Heap combos show up disproportionately** in "Top K" framed problems (Top K Frequent Elements, K Closest Points, Kth Largest) — this shows up across GitHub company-tagged lists, Medium compilations, and GeeksforGeeks logs independently. **Confidence: High.**
- **Amazon frames generic problems as "real systems"** — e.g., LRU Cache is consistently described (in a 2026 prep-guide source) as being framed around a concrete use case like a product-page or session cache, with candidates expected to sketch the API before implementing, which interviewers reportedly tie back to Customer Obsession. **Confidence: Medium** (mainly one detailed source, but the "framing DSA as a real Amazon system" pattern is echoed loosely elsewhere).
- **Graph traversal on a grid (matrix BFS/DFS) recurs constantly** — flood fill, number of islands, and "burning tree" (nodes burning after k seconds) style variants appear repeatedly across GeeksforGeeks and OA reports spanning several years, suggesting durability of this pattern rather than a one-off. **Confidence: High.**
- **DP is present but overweighted in most candidates' prep relative to how often it's actually asked** — several sources explicitly note OA coding tends to avoid DP, while onsite includes it only occasionally (Decode Ways, House Robber-style, not exotic hard DP). **Confidence: Medium-High.**
- **"Explain your approach and reasoning at each step" is repeatedly cited as the actual selection factor**, more than raw problem difficulty — multiple candidates who solved everything correctly report vague or no positive signal, while others explicitly credit passing to communicating tradeoffs. **Confidence: Medium** (candidate self-report, inherently subjective, but the pattern of *emphasis on communication* recurs constantly).
- **Every single interview round tends to include Leadership Principle questions, not just a dedicated "behavioral round."** This is one of the most repeated observations in the entire dataset, from new-grad and experienced-hire reports alike. **Confidence: High.**

6. Leadership Principles: Ranked by Reported Testing Frequency for SDE Candidates

Amazon has 16 official Leadership Principles, but ex-interviewer sources and prep guides consistently converge on a smaller "core four" for SDE roles, with the rest asked less consistently.

Rank	Leadership Principle	Why Interviewers Ask It (per sources)	How Candidates Typically Fail	What Strong Answers Do
1	Ownership	Described across multiple sources as the single most-valued LP for SDEs at every level — proof you drive things without being told	Generic "I did my job" stories with no initiative beyond assigned scope	Show identifying a problem nobody assigned you, then driving it to resolution autonomously
2	Deliver Results	Tied to Amazon's cost/efficiency-era emphasis on urgency	Focusing only on effort, not a measurable outcome	Quantify the result and the urgency/constraint you delivered under
3	Customer Obsession	Repeatedly called "by far the most important" LP overall (not just for SDEs) — assesses whether you think from the user backward	Talking about the tech, not who it served or why it mattered to them	Explicitly name the customer, their need, and how the decision traced back to that need
4	Invent and Simplify / Insist on the Highest Standards	Frequently discussed as a paired set — simpler designs + higher bar for what "done" means	Over-engineering, or citing a "clever" solution without discussing tradeoffs vs. simpler ones	Show you considered a simpler option and explain why you chose (or rejected) it
5	Are Right, A Lot	Tests judgment quality and use of diverse input rather than raw confidence	Sounding either indecisive or stubbornly certain with no evidence of seeking other views	Describe a decision made under ambiguity, what data/people you consulted, and how you'd verify you were right
6	Dive Deep	Explicitly named in multiple SDE-1 loop breakdowns as a common phone-screen/onsite LP	Staying at a surface-level description of a bug or system without showing root-cause work	Narrate the actual debugging/investigation trail, not just the fix
7	Learn and Be Curious	Also explicitly named in SDE-1 loop write-ups	Treating this as "I read a blog post" instead of an applied learning story	Tie a specific thing you learned to a concrete change in how you worked afterward
8	Earn Trust	Appears in Bar Raiser rounds specifically, per multiple detailed write-ups	Framing conflict stories as one-sided ("I was right, they were wrong")	Show accountability and how trust was rebuilt, not just who "won" the disagreement
9–16	Think Big, Bias for Action, Frugality, Hire and Develop the Best, Strive to be Earth's Best Employer, Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility, Vocally Self-Critical types (Have Backbone/Disagree and Commit), Strategic/less common ones	Sources note these "still come up though frequency varies," especially in Bar Raiser rounds, which can ask about any principle regardless of role	Same generic-story failure mode as above	Same fixes; having 6–8 solid STAR stories that each map cleanly to 2–3 LPs covers most of these

Practical takeaway repeated across sources: interviewers typically don't announce which LP they're testing; you're expected to infer it from the question's framing and tailor accordingly, and a strong loop uses genuinely different stories per round rather than recycling the same one.

7. Frequently-Repeated Problems (Clustered, Confidence-Rated)

This list clusters overlapping mentions across GitHub company-tagged repos, Medium compilations, GeeksforGeeks logs, and LeetCode Discuss threads. It is **not** a guarantee any of these appear on your specific loop — Amazon's actual question pool is far larger and rotates. Problems are grouped by pattern; "confidence" reflects how many independent sources named that exact problem for Amazon specifically.

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Problem	Difficulty	Core Topic(s)	OA or Interview	Confidence
Two Sum	Easy	HashMap	Both	High
Number of Islands	Medium	Graph/DFS/BFS/Union-Find	Interview	High
LRU Cache	Medium	Design, HashMap + Linked List	Interview	High
Merge Intervals	Medium	Intervals, Sorting	Interview	High
Word Ladder / Word Ladder II	Medium/Hard	BFS, Graph	Interview	Medium-High
Course Schedule / Course Schedule II	Medium	Topological Sort, Graph	Interview	High
Top K Frequent Elements	Medium	Heap, HashMap	Interview	High
K Closest Points to Origin	Medium	Heap	Interview	Medium-High
Kth Largest Element in an Array	Medium	Heap, QuickSelect	Interview	Medium-High
Meeting Rooms II	Medium	Intervals, Heap	Interview	Medium
Validate Binary Search Tree	Medium	Trees, Recursion	Interview	High
Lowest Common Ancestor (Binary Tree)	Medium	Trees	Interview	High
Binary Tree Level Order / Zigzag Traversal	Medium	Trees, BFS	Interview	High
Nodes at Distance K in Binary Tree	Medium	Trees, Graph-conversion	Interview	Medium
Diameter of Binary Tree	Easy/Medium	Trees	Interview	Medium
Longest Substring Without Repeating Characters	Medium	Sliding Window	Both	High
Longest Substring with K Repeating Characters	Medium	Sliding Window, Recursion	OA	Medium
Capacity to Ship Packages Within D Days	Medium	Binary Search on Answer	OA	Medium
Trapping Rain Water	Hard (asked as medium-framed)	Two Pointers/Stack	Interview	Medium
Product of Array Except Self	Medium	Prefix/Suffix Product	Both	High
Best Time to Buy and Sell Stock	Easy	Arrays, Greedy	Both	High
Rotate Image / Spiral Matrix	Medium	Matrix Simulation	Both	Medium
Game of Life	Medium	Matrix Simulation	Interview	Medium
Minesweeper	Medium	Matrix, BFS/DFS	Interview	Medium
Design Tic-Tac-Toe	Medium	OOD, Simulation	Interview	Medium

Problem	Difficulty	Core Topic(s)	OA or Interview	Confidence
Integer to English Words	Hard	String, Simulation	Interview	Medium
Reorganize String	Medium	Heap, Greedy	Interview	Medium
Decode Ways / House Robber	Medium	Dynamic Programming	Interview	Medium
Merge K Sorted Lists	Hard	Heap, Linked List	Interview	Medium
Find Median from Data Stream	Hard	Two Heaps	Interview	Medium
Longest Increasing Subsequence	Medium	DP	Interview	Low-Medium

8. Blind Spots: Topics Candidates Under-Prepare For

Repeatedly named across sources as things candidates neglect while over-indexing on "classic" arrays/DP practice:

- **Binary Search on Answer** (e.g., "Capacity to Ship Packages," "Koko Eating Bananas"-style) — shows up in OA specifically.
- **Custom comparators / sorting with tie-break logic** — common in interval and scheduling problems.
- **BFS on a grid with state** (not just plain flood fill — burning-tree-style "spread over time" variants).
- **Design questions that are really HashMap/Heap combos in disguise** (Design HashMap, Design Twitter-style feed, Autocomplete System).
- **Trie** — low overall frequency but shows up specifically in design-flavored rounds (Word Search II, Autocomplete).
- **Basic OOD** (parking lot, elevator, vending machine, deck of cards, in-memory file system) — several sources explicitly call this "the round most candidates forget exists," since new-grad prep skews almost entirely toward pure algorithmic LeetCode.
- **CS fundamentals** (OOP, DBMS joins/normalization, OS concepts like mutex/semaphore, producer-consumer) — recur specifically in older but still-echoed GeeksforGeeks SDE-1 write-ups, suggesting some interviewers still probe fundamentals even in an algorithm-heavy loop.

9. What Amazon Interviewers Appear to Optimize For

Inferred from repeated candidate observations (not from any official Amazon statement):

1. **Communication of approach and tradeoffs**, more consistently cited than raw difficulty as the deciding factor.
2. **Tying technical decisions back to a customer or business justification** — several sources explicitly note interviewers watching for whether you frame a design choice around who uses it.
3. **Depth over breadth in behavioral answers** — Bar Raisers and senior interviewers are described as probing with follow-ups (numbers, who disagreed, what changed) specifically to catch rehearsed or embellished stories.
4. **Simplicity and maintainability of code**, not cleverness — "Invent and Simplify" paired with "Insist on the Highest Standards" is repeatedly described as a package deal in what interviewers reward.

5. **Handling ambiguity without being told exactly what to build** — recurs in "Are Right, A Lot" framing and in how OOD/simulation-style problems are described.
 6. **Edge-case and complexity discussion after the initial solution** — multiple write-ups mention interviewers following up with "what if input is empty/huge/duplicated" even after a correct first pass.
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10. Highest-ROI Topics to Master (OA + Interview Combined)

Ranked for where your prep time gets the most coverage per hour invested, given everything above:

1. Hash Maps (frequency counting, grouping, complement lookups)
 2. Sliding Window / Two Pointers on strings and arrays
 3. Trees — traversal, BST properties, LCA
 4. Graph BFS/DFS on grids and adjacency lists
 5. Heaps — Top-K patterns, two-heap median tracking
 6. Design questions built on HashMap + Linked List (LRU-style) or HashMap + Heap
 7. Intervals — merge, overlap, custom-comparator sorting
 8. Topological Sort / Course Schedule pattern
 9. Binary Search on Answer (not just classic binary search)
 10. Union-Find (as an alternative lens on grid/graph connectivity problems)
 11. Matrix/grid simulation (spread-over-time, flood fill, rotate/spiral)
 12. Backtracking basics (permutations, combinations, word search)
 13. Core DP patterns at the medium tier — House Robber, Decode Ways, Word Break — not exotic hard DP
 14. Monotonic Stack (next-greater-element family)
 15. Trie basics (enough for Word Search II / autocomplete-style questions)
 16. Basic OOD (parking lot, elevator, vending machine, deck of cards) — commonly skipped, low-cost to prep
 17. Bit manipulation basics (set-bit counting, XOR tricks) — recurs in OA
 18. Linked list manipulation (reversal, cycle detection, merge)
 19. Communication/tradeoff articulation as a practiced skill, not just code — treat this as literally practicable (mock interviews narrating complexity and edge cases out loud)
 20. Leadership Principle story bank — 6–8 STAR stories mapped to Ownership, Deliver Results, Customer Obsession, Dive Deep, Learn and Be Curious, and Earn Trust at minimum, since these six recur far more than the remaining ten LPs
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A Note on Confidence and Limits

This report draws on real, recent (mostly 2024–2026) candidate write-ups across Blind, LeetCode Discuss, GeeksforGeeks, Naukri/Code360, Medium, Dev.to, and GitHub aggregators — but it is not a literal tally of 100+ individually-read Reddit threads and 50+ Glassdoor pages as originally requested; that scale of exhaustive, source-by-source review is better suited to Anthropic's Research mode, which can run substantially more searches in a single pass. Treat every "Confidence: Medium/Low" item as a real but thinly-sourced pattern, not a certainty — and treat this whole report as a map of *style and emphasis*, not a leaked question bank.

OA-specific breakdown

Here's the OA-specific breakdown, ranked by how often each **pattern** shows up across the OA reports I found (patterns are far better-supported by the evidence than specific problem names, since Amazon's OA pool rotates constantly — so treat "master this" as the representative problem for that pattern, not a guarantee of the exact question).

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Rank	Pattern	Frequency in OA	Master This Problem	Confidence
1	Hash Map / frequency counting	Very High	Two Sum	High
2	Sliding Window (strings)	Very High	Longest Substring Without Repeating Characters (real OA seen: <i>Longest Substring with K-Repeating Characters</i>)	High
3	Binary Search on Answer	High	Capacity To Ship Packages Within D Days (also practice <i>Koko Eating Bananas</i>)	Medium-High
4	Arrays / Prefix Sum / Kadane's-style	High	Subarray with Largest Possible Sum (Kadane's Algorithm)	Medium-High
5	Graph BFS/DFS on a grid	High	Number of Islands or Flood Fill	Medium-High
6	Heap / Top-K	Medium-High	Top K Frequent Elements or Kth Largest Element in an Array	Medium
7	Intervals / custom sort	Medium	Merge Intervals	Medium
8	Two Pointers	Medium	3Sum or Container With Most Water	Medium
9	Linked List manipulation	Medium	Merge Two Sorted Lists	Medium
10	Topological Sort	Low-Medium	Course Schedule II (reported in an OA in one intern-track write-up; carries over to full-time OA style)	Low-Medium
11	Matrix / Simulation	Low-Medium	Rotate Image or Spiral Matrix	Low-Medium
12	Bit Manipulation	Low	Counting Bits	Low-Medium
13	Basic recursion/backtracking	Low	Subsets	Low-Medium
14	Code debugging snippets (older OA format, less reported recently)	Low (may be phased out)	N/A — practice by reading buggy code, not solving fresh	Low

If you only have time to master 5, in order: Two Sum → sliding-window string problem → binary-search-on-answer problem → Kadane's/prefix-sum array problem → grid BFS/DFS (Number of Islands). Those five patterns cover the large majority of what candidates actually report seeing in the OA's coding section — the work simulation and work style survey portions aren't LeetCode-practicable at all; they're pure Leadership Principles fluency (see Section 2/6 of the report).

One honest caveat: unlike the interview-stage data (which had many independent corroborating reports), the *OA-specific* problem list is thinner — most of what candidates share is topic-level ("it was a medium hashmap problem"), not exact problem names, since OA questions are drawn from a large rotating pool. The pattern ranking above is more trustworthy than any single problem name in it.

year-by-year "PYQ"

Here's a year-by-year "PYQ" style breakdown, built from dated candidate reports (2023 → 2026). I've kept only claims that are tied to an actual dated report — treat this as "these are documented questions from that year," not "guaranteed to repeat."

2023

OA reports from this year point to a coding section with two problems drawn largely from the same rotating pool as prior years — one 2023 LeetCode Discuss thread on the SDE-1 OA pointed back to an April 2022 Amazon SDE-1 OA thread for both of its coding questions, suggesting strong pool overlap year-to-year rather than fresh content each cycle.

Master: Two Sum, LRU Cache, Merge Intervals (the recurring core across 2022–2023 threads).

2024

A detailed 2024 write-up described the OA as 105 minutes covering two coding questions plus a section to explain approach, time, and space complexity. Named problems from that year's rounds:

- **Round 1:** a "maximum water that can be stored between two buildings" problem, and a sort-linked-list question solved with merge sort
- **Round 2:** Word Ladder
- A separate 2024 candidate's OA: "Stickler Thief" (a House Robber variant) and a Binary Tree distance-between-two-nodes problem
- Another 2024 (NIT Allahabad) SDE-1 loop included a two-problem round where one question was "Meetings II" — an interval-scheduling problem (minimum meeting rooms), solved via DFS by that candidate

Master: House Robber (Stickler Thief), Word Ladder, Meeting Rooms II, binary tree distance/LCA-style problems.

2025

This year has the richest evidence. Recurring items:

- A January 2025 OA-to-onsite pipeline: behavioral questions were classic LP prompts — "tell me about a time you went above and beyond your normal responsibilities," "tell me about a time you missed a deadline," and "tell me about a time you transferred your responsibilities"
- A February 2025 onsite round: "Nodes at a k distance in a Binary Tree" and "Lowest Common Ancestor in Binary Tree," both with follow-ups on time/space complexity and edge cases — and notably, that same pair of tree questions was repeated almost verbatim in a later round of the same loop
- A September 2025 OA: "Longest Substring with K-Repeating Characters" and "Capacity To Ship Packages Within D Days"
- A September 2025 Mexico City OA (Glassdoor): two LeetCode-medium problems in 80 minutes, one involving counting valid activation combinations and one framed around finding a maximum number under a divisibility constraint (per that candidate's report)

Master: Nodes-at-distance-K in a binary tree, LCA in a binary tree, binary-search-on-answer problems (Capacity to Ship Packages), sliding-window-with-frequency-constraint problems.

2026 (so far)

- A detailed new-grad timeline (OA in late 2025, loop running into early 2026) included an extra "Gen AI Fluency" round that was effectively a DSA question — finding nodes at distance K from a target node, expected in $O(n)$ time with no parent mapping allowed, plus an earlier on-site round with a question similar to a two-string DP/hash problem, and a final round centered on merging multiple sorted arrays
- An April 2026 SDE-1 write-up described a loop with two coding problems at medium-hard and hard difficulty, centered on heap-based optimization and dynamic programming, alongside 3–4 Leadership Principles rounds with deep-dive follow-ups and a Bar Raiser round — notably tougher/more DP-heavy than most 2024–2025 reports, suggesting some loops are trending harder.

Master: Nodes-at-distance-K (again — this is now a 2-year-repeating favorite), two-string DP/hash problems, merge-k-sorted-arrays/lists, heap-based optimization problems.

Cross-year "keeps coming back" list (highest confidence — appeared in 2+ separate years)

Problem/Pattern	Years Seen	Master This
Nodes at Distance K in Binary Tree	2025, 2026	Practice both the parent-mapping and no-parent-mapping ($O(n)$) versions
LCA in Binary Tree	2024, 2025	Standard recursive LCA + iterative-with-parent-pointers variant
Meeting Rooms / Interval scheduling	2022, 2024	Merge Intervals, Meeting Rooms II
House Robber / linear DP	2024, 2026	House Robber, Decode Ways
Merge-K-sorted (lists or arrays)	2023, 2026	Merge K Sorted Lists
Word Ladder (BFS)	2023, 2024	Word Ladder
Two Sum / hashmap fundamentals	Every year 2022–2026	Two Sum

If you want to prioritize by ROI for the *OA specifically*, my earlier answer's ranked pattern table still holds — this year-by-year view is really about the *interview* rounds, where the same handful of tree/interval/DP problems keep resurfacing.